THE PROGRAM TROUBLESHOOTING FIELD GUIDE

JR STRENGTH & FITNESS

THE TRAINER'S COACH

VAULT

FIND THE PROBLEM BEFORE THE FIX.

When a client stops progressing, the easy move is a new program. This is the review I run first: the goal, the record, then the plan. It ends with one written adjustment and a date to check it.

RESOURCES. SYSTEMS. STANDARDS.

INSIDE

WHO IT'S FOR

Working trainers and strength coaches

WHAT YOU LEAVE WITH

One documented adjustment, with the rule for reviewing it

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01 THE QUESTION
02 THE ORDER
03 EXECUTION
04 PROGRAM
05 ADJUSTMENT
06 THE TALK

01 / THE QUESTION

NAME THE REAL QUESTION.

"The program isn't working" needs unpacking before anything changes. Pin down the outcome, the phase and the evidence before you pick a new exercise or method.

CLIENT REFERENCE private ID, not a name

CURRENT GOAL

CURRENT PHASE, AND WHAT IT'S FOR

WHAT PROGRESS SHOULD LOOK LIKE RIGHT NOW

WHAT I SAW THAT STARTED THIS REVIEW

> This is how I review a stalled client. It isn't a validated diagnostic tool, and it doesn't replace scope of practice, clinical referral or your own judgment. Keep client health details in private records, never in a newsletter or marketing form.

02 / THE ORDER

REVIEW IT IN THIS ORDER.

The order keeps the review tied to the original goal. It doesn't mean an exercise or workload that's clearly wrong has to wait its turn.

01	**SAFETY OR SCOPE FIRST**	Pain, a new health concern or a restriction may need modification or referral before any progression troubleshooting.
02	**GOAL, TIMELINE, MEASURE**	Are they realistic, and is the measure the right one?
03	**PRESCRIBED VS COMPLETED**	Compare what was written with what actually got done.
04	**IF COMPLETION IS PATCHY**	Find the obstacle and work on that first.
05	**IF COMPLETION IS SOLID**	Now review the program and the recovery context around it.
06	**SMALLEST USEFUL CHANGE**	Pick the adjustment that fits the problem you actually found.
07	**WRITE THE REVIEW DOWN**	What gets checked, and when.

WHERE THIS CLIENT SITS IN THE ORDER RIGHT NOW

03 / EXECUTION

WHAT WAS DONE?

Fill this in with the client, not about them. You're looking for the gap between the plan and the week they actually had.

PLANNED INPUT	COMPLETED	EVIDENCE	BARRIER OR UNCERTAINTY
TRAINING FREQUENCY			
MAIN PRESCRIBED WORK			
PROGRESSION AND EFFORT INSTRUCTIONS			
OTHER AGREED BEHAVIORS TIED TO THE GOAL			

ASK WITHOUT BLAME

FOUR QUESTIONS FOR THE CLIENT

01 Which part of the plan was hardest to carry out?

02 What did you change, and why?

03 Which instructions were unclear?

04 What would make next week more workable?

When a plan keeps failing to fit someone's life, the structure needs the work.

04 / PROGRAM AND CONTEXT

NOW CHECK THE PLAN.

The client did the work they agreed to. Another adherence reminder won't help, so look at the prescription.

		YES	NO	UNSURE
01	The progression rule fits what this phase is for.	☐	☐	☐
02	The planned progression was actually applied.	☐	☐	☐
03	The workload matches their current capacity and circumstances.	☐	☐	☐
04	The training records show solid execution.	☐	☐	☐
05	Schedule, sleep, stress and fatigue haven't changed much.	☐	☐	☐
06	Each exercise still suits the job it's there to do.	☐	☐	☐
07	The measure can show the kind of change we expect.	☐	☐	☐

WHAT THE RECORDS SHOW the pattern, not one session

> Recovery observations raise questions. On their own they don't diagnose anything or prove why a plateau happened.

05 / THE ADJUSTMENT

WRITE THE CHANGE DOWN.

One record per adjustment. If you can't fill a box, that's a sign the change isn't ready yet.

OBSERVATION

WORKING EXPLANATION including what's uncertain

THE ADJUSTMENT

WHY THIS ADJUSTMENT FITS

WHAT STAYS THE SAME so the comparison still means something

WHAT WE'LL MONITOR

REVIEW DATE OR CONDITION

WHAT WOULD MAKE US REASSESS SOONER

> Don't change several things at once just to make the program look new. If several changes really are needed, write down why, and accept that you won't be able to separate their effects.

06 / WORKED EXAMPLE

TWO OUT OF THREE SESSIONS.

A hypothetical client, to show the reasoning. No result is claimed. This isn't a success story.

HYPOTHETICAL EXAMPLE	One adjustment record, filled in
OBSERVATION Booked for three sessions a week, the client regularly completes two. One appointment keeps colliding with work.	**WORKING EXPLANATION** The written schedule doesn't match their recurring availability. That says nothing yet about whether the exercises are working.
ADJUSTMENT Review the goal, then rebuild the week around the appointments they can reliably keep, with the work redistributed by the coach.	**MONITORING** Attendance, completion of the revised work, and the performance record that matters for the goal.
REVIEW Agree on a review point that fits the goal and the change. Reassess sooner if participation or tolerance becomes a concern.	

01	**THE OBSERVATION IS A RECORD**	It's what the calendar shows, with no judgment of the client attached.
02	**THE EXPLANATION STOPS AT THE EVIDENCE**	A schedule problem doesn't prove the exercises were wrong.
03	**THE REVIEW FITS THE CHANGE**	No fixed deadline. The check matches what was adjusted.

07 / THE CONVERSATION

EXPLAIN IT IN ONE BREATH.

Say the decision out loud the way you'd say it to the client. If a blank won't fill, go back a page.

We were aiming to improve _____. The records show _____. The main issue looks like _____, although _____ is still uncertain. We'll adjust _____ and watch _____. We'll review it _____.

THE GUIDE STAYS YOURS.

Use it on the next stalled client.

NOTES FROM THE FLOOR

FOR COACHES WHO WANT MORE.

My newsletter covers programming decisions, client communication and the systems behind the Vault. Pick "I coach or train others" when you join.

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